

COLORADO BEETLE

Strategy: Leaf eater

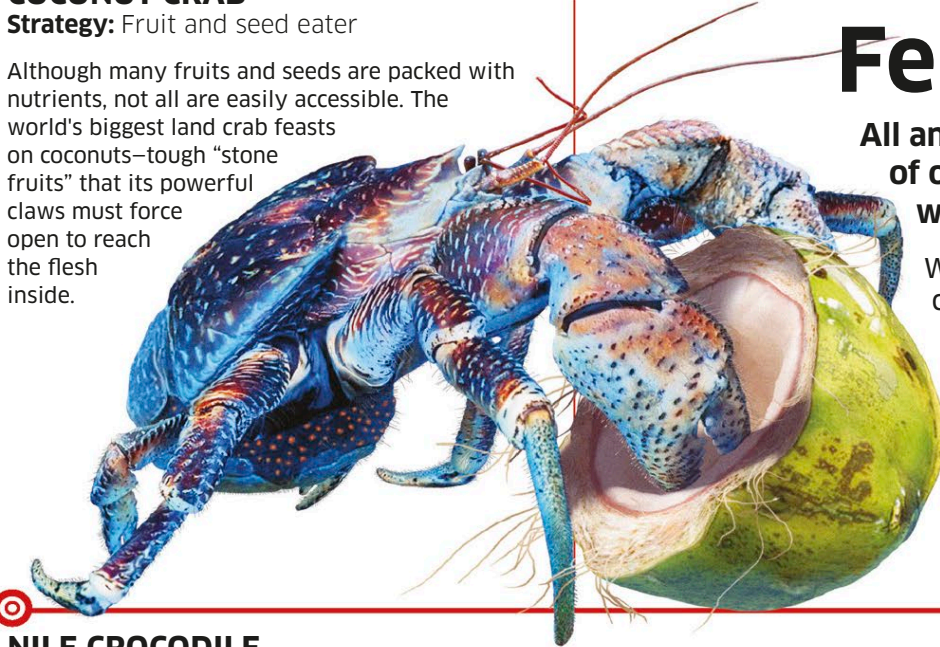
Leaves can be a bountiful source of food, but leaf eaters must first get past a plant's defenses. Many are specialized to deal with particular plants, such as the Colorado beetle, which eats potato plant leaves that are poisonous to other animals.



COCONUT CRAB

Strategy: Fruit and seed eater

Although many fruits and seeds are packed with nutrients, not all are easily accessible. The world's biggest land crab feasts on coconuts—tough “stone fruits” that its powerful claws must force open to reach the flesh inside.



NILE CROCODILE

Strategy: Predator

Carnivores that must kill to obtain food not only need the skill to catch their prey, but also the strength to overpower it. Some predators rely on speed to chase prey down, but the Nile crocodile waits in ambush instead. It lurks submerged at a river's edge until a target comes to drink, then grabs the prey with its powerful jaws and pulls the struggling animal underwater to drown it.

VAMPIRE BAT

Strategy: Parasite

Some animals obtain food directly from living hosts—without killing them. Blood suckers, such as the vampire bat, get a meal rich in protein. The bat attacks at night, and is so stealthy that the sleeping victim scarcely feels its bites.



HAGFISH

Strategy: Scavenger

Deep-sea hagfishes are scavengers: they feed on dead matter. By tying themselves into knots, they are able to brace themselves against the carcasses of dead whales so that their spiny jawless mouths can rasp away at the flesh.



Feeding strategies

All animals need food to keep them alive—in the form of other organisms, such as plants and animals. Many will go to extreme lengths to obtain their nutrients.

Whether they are plant-eating herbivores, meat-eating carnivores, or omnivores that eat many different foods, all animals are adapted to their diets. Every kind of animal has evolved a way for its body to get the nourishment it needs. Some animals only ever drink liquids, such as blood, or filter tiny particles from water, while others use muscles and jaws to tear solid food to pieces.

Mighty bite

The crocodile's jaws can deliver a bite that has three times more force than a lion's.

Easy prey

Zebras are often attacked while crossing large rivers.

